

The Costume Audit.

How deep the costume actually goes.

This is the companion to the seven-day Costume Audit. The five-domain prompts in the audit tool produce the surface inventory. This manual is what takes you past the surface — into the layers the surface answer protects, the patterns that keep the costume operating even while you appear to be doing the work, and the depth at which naming becomes architecture instead of vocabulary.

01 • Premise

What a costume actually is.

The costume is not metaphor. It is the literal set of identity components — postures, voices, defaults, suppressions, automatic responses — installed by the legacy operating system before you had the language to refuse any of them. It was built by every adult who held you, every institution you passed through, every legacy frequency you absorbed before you had the awareness to operate on what was being installed. By the time you had words, the costume had already taken shape.

The costume is not a flaw to fix. It is a survival adaptation that did its job. It got you through environments that needed you to be someone other than who you were. It earned you love, safety, recognition, and money in places where the unmediated version of you would have been punished, ignored, or expelled. The costume worked. That is exactly the problem. It worked so well, for so long, in environments that were not optimizing for who you actually were, that it became the operating layer you call yourself.

Most of what you experience as *my personality* is the costume. The audit is not about discrediting it — it is about separating it from you. Once it is named and inventoried, it stops being you and becomes something you can audit, edit, take off when you choose, or keep operating when it serves. The costume does not have to disappear. It has to stop running you in the background.

02 • The Depth Problem

Why you can only see so far from one position.

You can only see the costume to the depth your current position permits. This is the structural reason the audit takes more than ten minutes and more than one pass.

The costume is installed in layers — a surface layer you can see immediately, a second layer that becomes visible only after the first is named, a third visible only after the second, and so on. Each layer hides the next. The deepest layers were installed earliest and are the most invisible, because they predate the language you now use to think about yourself.

When you write the first answer to *name the costume*, you are writing the surface. The surface is real. It is also the version the costume itself wants you to find — because if you stop at the surface, the deeper layers stay safe.

The work of the audit is staying at it long enough that the surface answer becomes uninteresting. When you have written the surface answer for the third or fourth time and noticed it does not feel like the whole truth, that is the field cracking open. The next layer is now accessible. Most people stop at the first answer because the first answer feels like progress — and it is. But it is the floor of the work, not the ceiling.

Common patterns that keep the costume in place.

The patterns below keep the costume in place even while you appear to be doing the work. Knowing them by name is half of refusing them.

The articulate-loop.

You become very good at describing the costume in eloquent, intelligent language. You can write paragraphs about it. You can explain it to friends. The eloquence becomes the new costume. Articulation without operation is just the costume in literary clothing.

The self-deprecation hedge.

You name the costume in a way that softens it — *I'm just a perfectionist, I'm too nice, I'm a recovering people-pleaser*. These framings sound like honesty but they are the costume defending itself by claiming a charming version of the trait. The costume does not have to look noble. Strip the qualifiers.

The everyone-does-it generalization.

You pivot from your specific costume to *this is just human nature* or *everyone has these patterns*. Generalization is dilution. The audit only works on your specific configuration, not on humanity in aggregate.

The work-done declaration.

You write the surface answer and declare the audit complete. The costume is happy with this — you got the satisfaction of doing the work without the cost of seeing past the surface. Real audits are not declared complete; they get refined.

The blame substitution.

You write about what was done to you — the parents, the teachers, the culture — and call it audit. Naming origin is useful. It is also the costume's preferred subject change. The audit is about what you operate now, not what was installed then.

The intellectualization escape.

You move from concrete observation to abstract framework. *The costume is the construct of conditioning that emerges from...* — and now you are doing theory, not audit. Audit is in the specifics: what did you do today, in what room, that the costume operated in.

If you notice any of these moves, the costume is intact and defending itself. The move is to stop, return to the specific room, and ask the question at one level of depth more uncomfortable than the answer that came easily.

How each costume is actually built.

The five-domain map in the audit is the surface architecture. Each domain has depth beneath it that the surface prompt only hints at. What follows is the layer below the surface answer in each one.

Work and Career.

The surface costume here is *the professional* — the version that shows up to be employable. Beneath that is the role you took on within the structure of work itself: the over-deliverer who proves worth through volume, the peacekeeper who absorbs interpersonal cost so others don't have to, the quiet competent who keeps being the one who gets the work done while others get the credit, the expertise-hoarder who makes themselves load-bearing because being load-bearing is how you stay safe. Beneath that is the deepest layer: the relationship to *worth itself* that work was teaching you. Did you learn that worth is contingent on output? On hours? On approval? On not-causing-trouble? That layer is the foundation, and it shows up in every other domain.

Family of Origin.

The surface costume here is *the role* — the responsible one, the funny one, the difficult one, the easy one, the achiever, the protector. Beneath that is what the family system needed you to be in order to stay coherent. Families are systems; every member plays a function the system requires. You may have been carrying a function the family could not survive without — emotional stabilizer, identified problem, referee, escape valve. The deepest layer is the founding cost: what part of yourself did you have to suppress for the family system to keep working? That suppression is still active. It still operates in any room that resembles the family system in shape.

Intimate and Romantic.

The surface costume here is the version of you that shows up wanting to be wanted. Beneath that is the *strategy* the costume runs to secure desire — performing, withholding, anticipating, smoothing, asking-without-asking, never-asking-at-all. Beneath that is the truth the strategy was designed to hide: the version of you that does the wanting plainly, that asks for what it wants directly, that does not know how to function inside the strategic mode and therefore got buried. Most people have not seen the un-strategic version of themselves in love since adolescence — possibly never. That is the layer the audit is reaching for.

Social and Public.

The surface costume here is the curated version — the one calibrated to the audience. Beneath that is the *belonging strategy*: how you ensure you are kept in the group, how you read the room before you speak,

what you trim from yourself before walking in. Beneath that is the foundational fear the strategy guards against: being expelled, being seen as wrong, being made small, being made invisible. Social rooms feel exhausting to most people not because of the people in them but because the costume operating there is the most actively maintained one — the one most calibrated, in the moment, to the most variable input.

Money.

The surface costume here is the financial pattern — the relationship to earning, spending, asking, owing, having. Beneath that is the *frequency* the pattern operates on: scarcity (there is never enough), shame (wanting is greedy), invisibility (do not be seen by money), or unworthiness (people like me do not get this). Beneath that is the deepest layer: the *prohibition*. Most adults inherited a prohibition around money so deep they have never named it as a prohibition — *it is not okay for me to have this, want this, ask for this, keep this*. The prohibition is the load-bearing costume. Until it is named, every financial decision routes through it silently.

The single move that takes you deeper.

The single move that takes you past the surface in any domain: **ask the question one level of depth more uncomfortable than the easy answer.**

If your first answer to *name the costume* is *I'm a perfectionist*, the next-level question is: *what does the perfectionism guard against?* If your next answer is *fear of being wrong*, the next-level question is: *what was the cost of being wrong, the first time you learned to fear it?* You keep going until the answer is specific, embodied, and uncomfortable. That is the depth you were looking for.

A simple rule: if the answer feels good to write, you are still on the surface. If the answer is hard to write but obviously true, you are at the layer the audit is for. If the answer is so hard you can barely write it, you have hit a layer worth saving and returning to.

The audit is not testing your honesty in the moment. It is laying down a record you can come back to in a week, a month, a year, and see the layer you could not see when you first wrote it. Save what you write. Re-read it. The next layer often becomes visible only on the second pass.

06 · Sovereignty

Why the depth pays.

Every costume layer named is a layer the architecture loses on you. The system was built on the assumption that the costume runs invisibly. Once it is named — even badly named, even partially named — it can no longer fully run you. The naming is the install. The depth of the naming is the depth of the install.

There is a level where the entire costume becomes visible as architecture, not identity. From that level, the costume can still be operated when it is useful. It can be put on for an evening, for a meeting, for a stretch of years if the situation demands. But it no longer runs you. You run it. That is sovereignty in this domain — the costume returned to its proper status as a tool, not as the operator.

The path to that level is the depth you bring to these seven days. Surface audit produces surface install. The deeper you go now, the fewer costumes you have to peel back later. The system is hoping you will stop at the surface, declare the work done, and move on. If you do, the deeper layers continue to run you, and Phase 2 will be working against a foundation that is still partly the costume's. If you go deep, Phase 2 has somewhere to build from.

This is the work. The ten minutes is the close-out. The work is the day, the noticing, the questions you keep returning to during the spaces between. The audit is the artifact. The architecture is what you build with it.

For the second pass.

Use these on a second pass through the audit, after the surface answers are saved. Bring them in on Day 6 or 7 if you want to push past the first install.

Work.

What did you learn worth was tied to, before you had a word for *worth*? What does your costume cost the people you work with — not what does it cost you? When was the last time you asked for what you actually wanted at work, in plain language?

Family of Origin.

What function did the family need you to play that no one named out loud? What part of you did the family system not have room for? If you stopped playing your role tomorrow, what would the family have to face that it has been protected from?

Intimate and Romantic.

What does your costume secure that you are afraid to ask for directly? What version of yourself has the person closest to you never seen? When was the last time you wanted something out loud, plainly, without strategy?

Social.

What do you trim from yourself before walking into a room? What opinion have you not said out loud in the last month because the room would not have wanted it? Where do you go for the version of yourself that does not need the audience?

Money.

What is the prohibition? Name it in a single sentence — *it is not okay for me to ___ around money*. What did the people who installed this prohibition believe about money? What would change in your life if the prohibition lifted tomorrow?

The costume was running you. Naming it is how it stops.